

Gear — Loop Experience 2 earplugs

What they are. Reusable filtered earplugs (the *Tomorrowland* x *Loop Experience 2* colourway). Unlike foam plugs, they lower the whole sound level fairly **evenly across frequencies** rather than just killing the highs — so music (and your own voice) stays natural, just quieter.

Spec	Value
Attenuation	17 dB SNR (12 dB NRR)
Filter character	Even/low-colouration — keeps sound "crisp," music-focused
Fit	4 silicone tip sizes (XS-L); seal per ear matters
Louder-night option	<i>Experience 2 Plus</i> adds the Loop Mute insert for extra reduction on demand

Owned as of: August 2026 — delivered, in testing.

Why Aaron bought them — hearing protection

Aaron sings/watches at loud karaoke rooms; the Brighton Hotel measures around **105 dB** just standing there (see [memory/006-brisbane-venues-timezone.md](#)). At 105 dB, safe unprotected exposure is only minutes. Knocking ~15–17 dB off brings that to roughly **88–90 dB**, where safe exposure is hours — a large cut in dose (every 3 dB roughly halves the sound energy). This alone justifies them.

Real-world caveat: the 17 dB is a lab figure with a perfect seal. Work the tip sizes until each ear gives a clear "sealed" drop; an uneven seal skews the pitch reference between ears.

Do they help the singing? — Tested. No.

The A/B was run on 4 Aug 2026: *Do Wah Diddy*, same song, same session, plugs in vs plugs out. The result went the opposite way to the prediction.

Do Wah Diddy	Median pitch deviation	Clean entries
Earplugs in	20 cents	31.1%
Earplugs out	10 cents	40.3%

Plugs in measured worse on both counts — twice the pitch deviation and ~9 points fewer clean entries. See [memory/013-earplugs-hurt-pitch.md](#).

Why the prediction was wrong

The reasoning *for* them was the **occlusion effect**: your own voice reaches your ears partly by bone conduction, normally leaking out the open ear canal; plug it and that gets trapped, so your voice sits louder against the band. That part is real — they do make you easier to hear.

What it missed is that hearing yourself *louder* is not the same as hearing yourself *accurately*. Occlusion boosts the low frequencies of your own voice and changes its timbre inside your head, so the reference you're matching against is distorted. Given [memory/012-pitch-matching-struggle.md](#) — conscious pitch matching is already your weak point, and you sing most in tune when your voice "just goes there" — a louder but colour-shifted self-signal appears to pull you further off, not closer.

Where that leaves them

- **Keep wearing them for hearing protection.** That was the real reason to buy them, the 105 dB exposure is genuinely harmful, and the protection case is untouched by this result.
- **Don't treat them as a singing aid**, and don't wear them for takes you intend to measure or for competition rounds.
- **Worth one more test before closing the book:** a single plug in the ear facing the speakers (protection where the blast is, one ear natural). That keeps most of the dose reduction while leaving an undistorted reference — the one configuration the A/B didn't cover.
- Relates to [memory/008-headphone-discomfort.md](#) — closed headphones at the stand also hurt your singing. Two different devices, same pattern: anything that replaces your natural self-monitoring seems to cost you accuracy.

Status: owned and in use for hearing protection. Rejected as a singing aid on measured evidence (4 Aug 2026).

Sources: Loop Experience 2 product spec (au.loopearplugs.com); occlusion effect (standard vocal-pedagogy acoustics); the paired Do Wah Diddy A/B analyses of 4 Aug 2026 (memory/013-earplugs-hurt-pitch.md), plus memory facts 009 and 012 and the gear/venue facts. Raw measures only — no scores.

Category: practice · **Topics:** [gear, hearing-protection, self-monitoring, onsets, competition] · Rendered from docs/practice/gear-loop-earplugs.md